

Duke Power Earns Feather For Its Cap With Osprey Program

By KATHLEEN CURRY

Staff Writer

Duke Power Co. has received special recognition for giving a bird a hand.

The company won the 1987 North Carolina "Take Pride in America" Award for its volunteer help in reintroducing ospreys to the Lake Norman area. The Carolina Raptor Center had solicited Duke's help with the eaglelike birds of prey that once nested regularly around local lakes.

More than 50 Duke Power biologists and environmental specialists, who regularly monitor the lake and land around Duke's McGuire Nuclear Station, have worked with raptor center volunteers to build platforms for future nests. Bird specialists hope the high wooden platforms, called "hacking sites," will encourage ospreys to build nests and call Lake Norman home again.

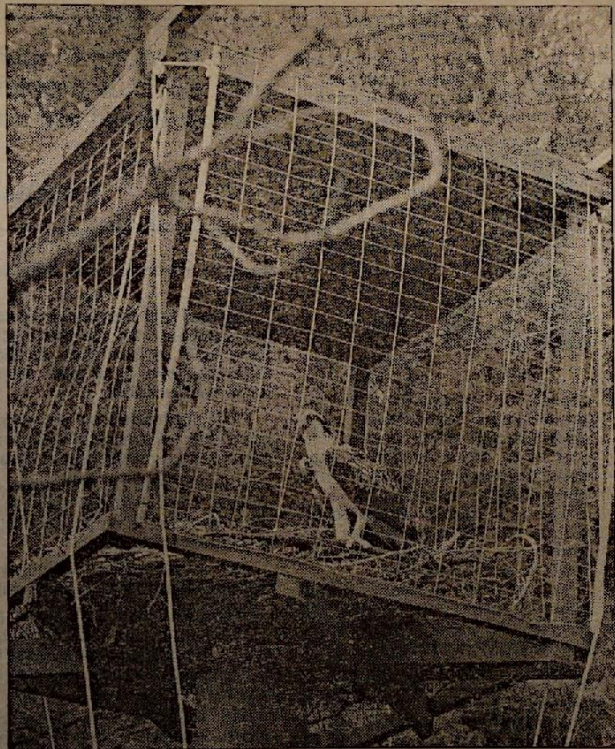
Ospreys are one of the few birds of prey who invariably return to their birthplace to raise their young. Once the chain is established, biologists hope, ospreys will once again flourish here.

Like some other birds and animals, ospreys were threatened in the 1960s and 1970s by pollution, mainly the DDT pesticide. Since DDT has been outlawed, the osprey population has slowly renewed itself in this country.

Duke Power biologists and other volunteers from Duke's Applied Sciences division started working with the raptor center in 1984. They would travel to Lake Mattamuskeet in Hyde County to find young ospreys. The ospreys were then raised in special hacking sites built by Duke and the raptor center. When they were old enough, they were released.

David Cathey and Robert Siler were two of Duke's coordinators for the project.

"We really enjoyed it; all our



A special hacking site used to raise ospreys on Lake Norman.

volunteers have," Siler said. "The raptor center is the one who really deserves the credit. We sure couldn't have done any of this without their help."

Ospreys stay away from their birthplaces at least one year, migrating long distances. They return to build nests and spawn when they are mature, but that may take several years, Siler said.

About 15 ospreys have been

raised and released since 1984, both at Lake Norman sites and at a newer site operated by the raptor center on Mountain Island Lake.

But so far, neither lake has had a successful nest from a returning osprey. Over the past two years several birds have returned to Lake Norman but did not produce eggs. Cathey and Siler speculate that the immaturity of the birds or problems with the nests — storms



Robert Siler holds osprey.

destroyed several nests — caused problems.

"They are young; they make mistakes," Cathey said. "We think it's not unlike a human's wedding night. It takes awhile."

Cathey, Siler and raptor center officials hope this spring, three

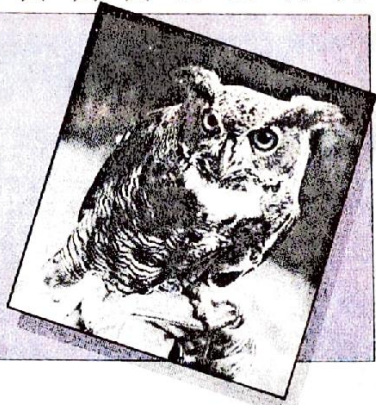
years after some of the earliest releases, is the charm.

"Last spring we were really encouraged because we had an active nest on the lake, before a bad storm tore it up," Siler said. "If we have one successful nest this spring, we'll be very happy."



Birds of prey

The Carolina Raptor Center cares for birds of prey like Yaiish, a great horned owl, at right.



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Shelby Calls In The Hawk To Fight Pigeons

A Cooper's hawk from Charlotte's Carolina Raptor Center was released in Shelby to help curb the town's pigeon population.

The release of the female Cooper's hawk named Swoop was part of an experiment between the nonprofit raptor center, the Carolinas' only official facility for the rehabilitation of injured birds, and the Uptown Shelby Association.

"To my knowledge, this is the first one we've actually released in a city," said Betty O'Leary, rehabilitation assistant for the seven-year-old center.



Scott, an American kestrel, is one of the birds helped at the Carolina Raptor Center.

Photo by Elizabeth S. Carr